

MODULE 44 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Exam Mechanics and Strategy

Three hours, seventy-five long questions, and a clock that does not care.

DOMAIN Cross-cutting EXAM WEIGHT All four MODULE 44 of 44

The format, precisely

- ◆ **75 questions in 180 minutes.** 65 are scored; 10 are unscored trials and are not identified.
- ◆ **Multiple choice** has one correct answer and three distractors. **Multiple response** has two or more correct among five or more.
- ◆ **Unanswered is scored as incorrect, and there is no penalty for guessing.** Never leave a question blank.
- ◆ A list of AWS service short names is available through the **Help button** during the exam.

ON THE EXAM

Ten unscored questions means about one in seven does not count, and you cannot tell which. Treat every question as real.

How it is scored

- ◆ **A scaled score from 100 to 1,000, with 750 to pass.** Scaling equates forms of slightly different difficulty.
- ◆ **Compensatory model:** AWS states you do not need to pass each section, only the exam overall.
- ◆ So a weak domain can be carried by strong ones. Domain 4 is 20%, and it cannot sink you alone.
- ◆ **Assume multiple-response needs every selection correct.** Sources disagree on partial credit; the conservative reading costs nothing.

ON THE EXAM

750 out of 1,000 is not 75%. Scaled scoring means you cannot convert it to a number of questions, so aim comfortably clear.

The time budget

- ◆ **2.4 minutes per question** on average. Some take forty seconds; a few take five minutes.
- ◆ **Checkpoints beat averages.** Question 25 by minute 60, question 50 by minute 120, leaving 60 for the rest and review.
- ◆ **The most common failure is spending six minutes on question twelve**, then rushing forty easy questions at the end.
- ◆ Flag and move at three minutes. A flagged question you return to is cheaper than three you never read properly.

ON THE EXAM

You cannot feel elapsed time reliably under pressure. Two checkpoints, at questions 25 and 50, are enough to catch drift early.

Reading a long stem

- ◆ **Read the final question first**, then the scenario. You will read the scenario knowing what to look for.
- ◆ **Find the constraint sentence.** It is usually about cost, downtime, a deadline, or who may change what.
- ◆ **Note the superlative:** MOST cost-effective, LEAST operational overhead, MOST secure. It decides between workable answers.
- ◆ Planted details are there to eliminate options. "The team has no Kubernetes experience" is not background.

ON THE EXAM

Most stems contain one sentence that eliminates two options. Finding it is faster than evaluating four answers in full.

Eliminating rather than choosing

- ◆ **Two options are usually implausible** and can go in seconds. That leaves a pair, which is module 41's territory.
- ◆ **An option that fails any stated requirement is out**, however elegant the rest of it is.
- ◆ **Watch for absolutes:** never, guarantee, ensure. Those demand preventive controls, not detective ones.
- ◆ If two options remain and both seem right, re-read the requirement rather than the options.

ON THE EXAM

Choosing between four is slow. Eliminating two, then resolving a pair on one property, is how the course has worked throughout.

The day itself

- ◆ **Breaks are unscheduled and the clock keeps running.** Decide in advance whether you will take one.
- ◆ Online proctoring needs a quiet room, a clear desk and a room scan. A test centre needs ID and early arrival.
- ◆ **A preliminary result appears immediately.** The official score report follows within a few business days.
- ◆ Fatigue is the real adversary at three hours. Sleep matters more than a final evening of revision.

ON THE EXAM

The section-level table on your score report is diagnostic, not a pass condition. Compensatory scoring means the total is what counts.

One date, restated

- ◆ **The last day to take SAP-C02 is 16 November 2026.** SAP-C03 registration opens on 27 October.
- ◆ If you are prepared, book now. Your certification is valid for three years regardless of which version you sit.
- ◆ You can retake after a 14-day wait, so leave room for a second attempt before the deadline if you book late.
- ◆ Check the AWS certification page before booking. This was recorded on 2 September 2026.

ON THE EXAM

If you are within a fortnight of ready, the retake window is the thing to plan around, not the exam date itself.

At the 100-minute mark you have completed 38 questions. Six are flagged for review. You are finding the scenarios long but not conceptually difficult.

There are 80 minutes and 37 questions remaining.

What should you do?

- ☐ A Speed up: aim for roughly 2 minutes per remaining question and defer the flagged six until the end
- ☐ B Go back and resolve the six flagged questions now, while they are fresh
- ☐ C Continue at the current pace and accept leaving some unanswered
- ☐ D Skip ahead to answer the easiest remaining questions first

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

- A

 Speed up, defer the flagged six
38 in 100 minutes is 2.6 each, slightly behind. 37 in 80 is 2.16 each, which is achievable, and unseen questions are worth more than flagged ones.
- B

 Resolve the flagged six now
Spends time on questions you have already attempted, while 37 unseen ones wait. An unseen question has a much higher expected return.
- C

 Continue as you are
At 2.6 minutes each, 37 questions needs 96 minutes and you have 80. That guarantees unanswered questions, which score as incorrect.
- D

 Cherry-pick the easy ones
You cannot tell which are easy without reading them, and scanning to choose costs the time you were trying to save.

THE SIGNAL

Do the arithmetic at the checkpoint rather than trusting the feeling. Slightly behind is recoverable; discovering it at question 60 is not.

A question says "Select THREE." You are confident about two options and genuinely cannot decide between the remaining three, all of which are plausible. You have used two minutes. You do not know whether partial credit applies.

What should you do?

- ☐ A Pick the most likely third, select three, flag it, and move on
- ☐ B Select only the two you are sure of, to avoid an incorrect selection
- ☐ C Spend another three minutes reasoning it through properly
- ☐ D Leave it unanswered and return at the end

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

- A

 Guess the third, flag, move on
There is no penalty for guessing, and selecting two when three are asked cannot be fully correct under either scoring rule. A one-in-three guess is free.
- B

 Select only two
Guarantees the answer is incomplete. If partial credit exists you gain nothing over guessing; if it does not, you have thrown the question away.
- C

 Three more minutes
Five minutes on one question, when you have already narrowed it to a one-in-three guess. The marginal return is very low.
- D

 Leave it blank
Unanswered is scored as incorrect. Blank is strictly worse than a guess, always.

THE SIGNAL

No penalty for guessing makes this arithmetic, not judgement. An incomplete selection can never beat a complete one with a guess in it.

Two options both appear to satisfy the scenario. One uses a Config rule with automatic remediation; the other uses a service control policy. You have re-read both options twice and cannot separate them.

You have not re-read the scenario.

What should you do?

- A Re-read the requirement, looking for an absolute like "never" or "guarantee" that forces the preventive control
- B Choose the Config rule, since detective controls are more flexible
- C Choose the SCP, since preventive controls are always stronger
- D Guess between them and move on immediately

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

- A

Re-read the requirement
The discriminator lives in the stem, not the options. Re-reading options you have already read twice cannot produce new information.
- B

Default to Config
Applies a general preference instead of reading the specific requirement. Sometimes right, for no reason.
- C

Default to the SCP
Preventive is not always correct. Module 25's scenario one showed a case where prevention broke legitimate incident response.
- D

Guess immediately
Reasonable if time is critical, and here one targeted re-read is likely to resolve it. Guess only after that fails.

THE SIGNAL

You have read the options twice and the scenario once. The information you are missing is almost certainly in the part you read least.

With three minutes left you have four unanswered questions, all flagged, all long. Reading one properly would take most of the remaining time.

There is no penalty for guessing.

What should you do?

- ☐ A Answer all four immediately with best guesses, then use any remaining seconds to reconsider one
- ☐ B Read and answer one carefully, leaving three blank
- ☐ C Read all four quickly and answer the two you can
- ☐ D Leave them; a wrong answer looks worse than no answer

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

- A

Guess all four, then reconsider
Four guesses have positive expected value; blanks have none. Securing all four first means running out of time costs nothing.
- B

One carefully, three blank
Trades three free guesses for one likely-correct answer. The arithmetic favours four attempts over one certainty.
- C

Read all four quickly
Risks the clock expiring mid-question with several still blank. Answer first, then read with whatever is left.
- D

Leave them blank
Factually wrong. Unanswered is scored as incorrect, and nobody sees which questions you guessed.

THE SIGNAL

Secure the guesses first, then improve them. Reversing that order means the clock can take questions off you entirely.

A practice exam returns 68%. The breakdown shows Domain 1 at 55%, Domain 2 at 74%, Domain 3 at 71% and Domain 4 at 70%. The exam is in two weeks.

Domain 1 is 26% of the real exam.

How should the remaining two weeks be spent?

- ☐ A Concentrate on Domain 1, since it is both the weakest and the second-heaviest domain
- ☐ B Spread revision evenly across all four domains
- ☐ C Concentrate on Domain 2, since it carries the most weight at 29%
- ☐ D Take more practice exams until the score improves

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the remaining two weeks be spent?

- A

 Domain 1
Weakest by 15 points and worth 26%. Weight times gap is the highest of the four, so improvement there moves the total score most.
- B

 Even spread
Treats a 55% domain and a 74% domain as equally urgent. Even effort produces uneven returns when the gaps differ this much.
- C

 Domain 2
Reads weight alone and ignores the gap. Improving 74% costs more effort per point than improving 55%.
- D

 More practice exams
Measures the problem repeatedly without addressing it. Practice exams diagnose; they do not teach.

THE SIGNAL

Prioritise by weight multiplied by gap, not by either alone. Domain 1 at 26% and 15 points behind is the clear target.

A candidate is consistently scoring 82% on practice exams and feels ready. It is 20 October 2026. They are considering waiting for SAP-C03 to certify on the newer content instead.

SAP-C03 registration opens 27 October; the last SAP-C02 date is 16 November.

What is the sound reasoning?

- ☐ A Sit C02 now: they are prepared, the credential is valid three years either way, and C03 content is not yet studied
- ☐ B Wait for C03, since a newer certification is more valuable
- ☐ C Wait for C03 and sit it in the first week, before question banks exist
- ☐ D Book C02 for 15 November, to maximise revision time

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the sound reasoning?

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>A Sit C02 now</p> <p>Prepared for the exam that exists, credential valid three years regardless, and C03 adds GenAI, agentic AI and post-quantum content they have not studied.</p> | <p>B Wait for C03</p> <p><i>The credential is the same certification either way. It means studying substantial new content while already prepared for the current one.</i></p> |
| <p>C Sit C03 in week one</p> <p><i>A brand-new exam with no preparation material and unstudied content, chosen for a reason that does not help the candidate pass.</i></p> | <p>D Book 15 November</p> <p><i>One day of margin before the deadline. A 14-day retake wait means a failure leaves no second attempt.</i></p> |

THE SIGNAL

Option D is the subtle error: it looks prudent and removes the retake window entirely. Book early enough to fail once.

What to carry out of this module

- ◆ **Never leave a question blank.** Unanswered scores as incorrect and guessing carries no penalty.
- ◆ **Checkpoints, not averages.** Question 25 by minute 60, question 50 by minute 120. Flag and move at three minutes.
- ◆ **Read the question first, then the stem,** and hunt for the constraint sentence and the superlative.
- ◆ **Prioritise revision by weight times gap,** and remember scoring is compensatory: you pass overall, not per domain.

ON THE EXAM

Book early enough to fail once. With the C02 deadline on 16 November, the 14-day retake wait is what to plan around.